



Empty your mind in 3 steps

A quick method to stop the wheel of thoughts and return to focus.

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*This guide is a self-knowledge
resource. It does not replace
therapeutic support.*

1. The mind that won't stop

There is a noise inside you that never goes quiet.

Not the noise of the children, or of work, or of traffic. It's interior noise. The voice (or voices) that speak without stopping, that comment on everything, that analyze everything, that worry about everything, that plan everything, that ruminate on everything. From morning to night. And sometimes, from night to morning.

You know this noise. You wake up and it's already there: the list of what you have to do, what was left unresolved yesterday, the worry about tomorrow, the guilt from the day before. You lie down and it continues: what you said and shouldn't have, what you didn't say and should have, what might go wrong, what already went wrong, what might one day go wrong.

The human mind produces, according to neuroscience estimates, between 60,000 and 70,000 thoughts per day. Most of them are not useful. Most are repetitions, variations on the same theme, loops that spin without going anywhere. And most (studies point to around 80%) are negative: worries, fears, self-criticism, catastrophic scenarios.

It's not your fault. The mind evolved to protect you, not to make you happy. Its job is to anticipate dangers, solve problems, keep you alive. And it does this very well. The problem is that, in the modern world, where dangers are rarely lions chasing you and are more frequently emails you haven't answered, the mind doesn't know how to stop. It treats every worry as a life-threatening situation. Every task to be done as an imminent danger. And it spins, spins, spins, without finding the exit, because the exit isn't solving one more problem. The exit is stopping.

And stopping is precisely what the mind refuses to do.

There is an image I often use: the mind is like a washing machine on spin cycle. The laundry spins at maximum speed, everything is mixed together, everything is in motion, and you can't see what's inside. You can't pull out a single item without first switching off the machine.

But you don't know how to switch it off. Or rather: you know you should switch it off, you know you "need to stop," you know you "should meditate," you know you "should breathe deeply." But when you try, the mind accelerates even more. As if it's afraid to stop. As if stopping were dangerous. As if, in the silence, something terrible might appear.

And many of us have developed strategies for dealing with the noise that, in truth, only feed it: endless scrolling on the phone (distracts, but doesn't calm), television (anesthetizes, but doesn't empty), eating without hunger (fills, but doesn't resolve), working more (keeps busy, but doesn't switch off). These are all ways of fleeing the noise, not treating it. And the noise, like a dammed river, accumulates pressure. And when the pressure is too great, the dam breaks: the anxiety attack, the insomnia that won't yield, the crying that comes from nowhere, the irritability that explodes over the children when the problem is not the children. These are symptoms of an overloaded mind saying: enough. Stop. Empty me.

I know a woman who described her mind as "a meeting where everyone talks at the same time and no one listens to anyone." She had ideas, worries, memories, plans, fears, tasks, all speaking simultaneously, all demanding attention, all convinced they were urgent. And she, in the middle of that chaotic meeting, felt paralyzed. Not from lack of intelligence. From excess of noise. The intelligence was there. She just couldn't hear herself.

If you recognize yourself in this, I want you to know: your mind is not broken. It's overloaded. And the difference matters. A broken mind needs repair. An overloaded mind needs to be emptied. And emptying a

mind is simpler than you think. Not easy (because the mind will resist). But simple.

This guide offers you three simple steps for emptying the machine. Not to eliminate thoughts (that's impossible and wouldn't even be desirable). But to organize them, separate the useful from the useless, and restore your ability to choose what to think about, instead of being thought by your thoughts.

2. Why thinking more doesn't solve it

Before the three steps, I need to explain to you why your habitual strategy (thinking more to resolve things) doesn't work.

When you have a problem, the natural reaction of the mind is to think about it. Analyze. Weigh pros and cons. Consider options. And for practical problems (which road to take, which professional decision to make, how to organize the budget), thinking works. The mind is an excellent tool for solving concrete problems.

But most of the thoughts that keep you awake are not concrete problems. They are emotional worries. "Will my child be all right?" "What if my marriage doesn't work out?" "What if I'm not enough?" "What if something goes wrong?" These are not problems to be solved by thinking. They are fears. And thinking about a fear doesn't resolve it: it amplifies it. Every time you think "what if something goes wrong?", the mind generates more scenarios of things that can go wrong. Every time you think "am I enough?", the mind generates more reasons why you might not be. Rumination feeds itself.

Science calls this "negative repetitive thinking." It's associated with anxiety, depression, insomnia, and a range of conditions that affect quality of life. Not because the thoughts are true. But because the brain, by repeating them, treats them as if they were. What you think repeatedly becomes, for your nervous system, as real as what you live.

And rumination has a particularly perverse effect on women. Studies show that women ruminate more than men. Not because they are weaker or more emotional. Because they are more socialized toward relational responsibility. You think about your children, your husband, your parents, your friends, your colleagues. You think about what they feel, what they need, what they might need. You think about them before thinking about yourself. And each of these layers of concern feeds the wheel.

And there is another thing: guilt amplifies rumination. "I shouldn't have said that." "I should have done differently." "What if I hurt him?" Guilt is the fuel of the thought wheel. And many women live in a cycle of guilt and rumination that feeds itself: guilt generates thought, thought generates more guilt, which generates more thought. Breaking this cycle is not done by thinking. It's done by acting differently. And the three steps I'll give you are exactly that: a way of acting when the mind wants you to stay trapped thinking.

And there is another phenomenon that science documents: "analysis paralysis." The more you think about a problem, the more options you see, the more risks you identify, the more uncertainty you feel, and the less capable you become of deciding. The mind, which was supposedly going to help you solve things, becomes the obstacle itself. Has it ever happened to you that you've thought so much about a decision that in the end you decided nothing? That you stayed in the same place, more exhausted and more confused than when you started? That is analysis paralysis. The mind spinning in circles, convinced that one more turn will resolve things, when in fact one more turn only tightens the knot.

The uncomfortable truth is this: most of the decisions you postpone, you postpone them not because you don't know the answer, but because you're afraid of the answer. And no amount of thinking will eliminate the fear. Thinking can help you understand the fear. But action is what dissolves it. And in order to act, you first need to stop thinking.

There is a common saying: "Sleep on it." And there is wisdom in it. Because sleeping is, literally, letting the mind rest. And when it rests, when it stops spinning, often the answer appears by itself. Not because the mind found it by thinking. But because the mind, in stopping, allowed something deeper (intuition, the body, the unconscious, call it what you will) to speak.

So thinking more doesn't solve things. What solves is changing channels. Not fleeing (that's distraction, it's temporary). But changing channels deliberately, with a method, with an intention. And that's what the three steps offer you.

3. The 3 steps: dump, sort, choose

Here is the method. It's simple. You can do it in ten minutes. Or five. You can do it with paper and pen, or just mentally (though paper helps enormously). You can do it sitting, lying down, or walking. What matters is that you do it with honesty.

Step 1: Dump

Take a piece of paper (or open the notes on your phone) and dump. Write down everything that's in your mind. Without order. Without logic. Without filtering. Without judging. Everything. "I have to call the doctor." "I'm worried about my child's school." "I don't feel well about my body." "I need to buy detergent." "My mum said something that hurt me." "I'm afraid I won't manage." "Tomorrow's meeting." "Money." "The laundry." "Guilt." "Exhaustion." Everything.

Don't worry about the quality of what you write. Don't worry if it seems ridiculous. Don't worry whether there are thirty things or three. The goal is to take what's inside and put it outside. Think of this as emptying a travel bag you've been carrying all day: while it's on your back, you don't really know what's in it, you only feel the weight. When you open

it and take everything out, you see: ah, this is it. And suddenly the weight has a shape, has a name, and is far more manageable than it seemed.

The mind works better when the content is externalized. It's like emptying a drawer to tidy it: first you scatter everything on the bed, then you organize.

You can use a variation if you prefer: instead of writing, speak. Pick up your phone, start the audio recording, and talk for three minutes without stopping. Say everything that comes into your head. Don't listen back afterwards (that's not what it's for). The act of verbalizing is already the dump. The sound of your own voice saying aloud what your mind repeats in silence has a surprising effect: it becomes real. And when it's real, it stops being a ghost. You can look at it. You can decide what to do with it.

It takes however long it takes. Three minutes, five minutes. You know you're done when you feel a slight relief. When the machine has slowed. When the chest has eased a little. That is the signal that the dump worked.

Step 2: Sort

Now look at what you wrote. And sort into three categories:

Action: things you can do something about. Call the doctor. Buy detergent. Prepare for the meeting. These are tasks. They have solutions. They can go on a to-do list, with a date and priority.

Accept: things you can't change right now. What your mum said. The weather. Uncertainty about the future. The imperfection of your body. These things are not to be resolved. They are to be recognized. "This hurts. I can't change it right now. And it's all right that it hurts." Saying this to yourself, with tenderness, is the most powerful gesture you can practice.

Rubbish: things that are neither action nor acceptance. They are recycled thoughts, fictional worries, invented scenarios, unfounded self-criticism. "What if the plane crashes?" (you're not traveling). "Everyone thinks I'm incompetent" (they don't). "I'll never manage" (you've managed until now). These go in the bin. You can even create a column on the paper with the heading "MENTAL RUBBISH" in big letters. There is something satisfying about categorizing a thought that tormented you all day as "rubbish." It strips away its power. It returns control to you.

Literally. Cross them out. Or imagine them being dragged into the virtual recycling bin. They don't deserve your mental space. They don't pay rent.

The sorting is the most liberating moment. Because when you look at the list and realize that half your thoughts are rubbish (unfounded worries, scenarios that will never happen, exaggerated self-criticism), something eases. The mind realizes: I was spending energy on illusions. And when energy stops going toward the rubbish, there's energy left for what matters.

Step 3: Choose

Now that the mind is cleaner, do one thing: choose. Choose one thought to carry with you over the next few hours. Not ten. One. It can be a task from your action list. It can be an intention for the day. It can be an anchoring phrase: "Today I do what I can and let go of the rest." What matters is that it's a chosen thought, not an imposed one.

There is a phrase I like to repeat: "You are not your thoughts. You are the one who observes the thoughts." It seems abstract, but try it: the next time a negative thought appears, instead of merging with it, notice it. "Look, the thought that I'm not enough has appeared again." You

don't fight it. You don't give it reason. You simply notice. Like someone watching a car pass in the street. You don't get in the car. You just watch. And the car passes. And you remain.

The difference between being thought and thinking is exactly this: the choice. When the mind thinks you, you are the passenger. When you think, you are the driver. And this exercise, done regularly (in the morning, before sleeping, or in moments of greatest agitation), returns the wheel to you.

A practical note: this exercise works better when done regularly. Not as an emergency (though it also works in an emergency), but as a habit. In the morning, upon waking: dump, sort, choose. Before sleeping: dump, sort, let go. In peak moments of anxiety: dump, sort, breathe. The more times you do it, the more natural it becomes. And the quicker it gets. At first it may take ten minutes. After some practice, five. After lots of practice, you do it mentally in two minutes while waiting in traffic.

And if you want a powerful complement: after doing the three steps, do something with your hands. It doesn't matter what: cook, draw, tidy a drawer, touch soil, knead bread. Your hands are the most direct connection between the mind and the body. And when the hands work, the mind calms. No theory needed. Just try it.

And there is something many women discover when they do this exercise: the thoughts that occupy the most space in the mind are rarely the most important ones. They're the noisiest. It's like in a room full of people: the one who speaks the loudest isn't necessarily the one with the most to say. And when you empty the room, when you silence the noise, what remains is often surprising. A quiet wish. An old desire. A clarity that was there, beneath the noise, waiting to be heard.

4. Infonte bridge

If this exercise helped you, if you felt that by emptying your mind something opened, I want to tell you there is a space created exactly for this: for what happens after the emptying.

Infonte is the space where the empty mind meets creativity. Not creativity in the sense of "beautiful art" or "special talent." Creativity in the sense of creating from yourself. Of letting, from the silence, something emerge. A word. An idea. An image. A direction. Infonte is the inner spring, the wellspring that only reveals itself when the noise stops.

Why do so many people have their best ideas in the shower? Because the shower is one of the few moments of the day when the mind is not being solicited. And when the mind rests, creativity wakes. Infonte is that principle transformed into a space: a place where you can empty, create, and discover what emerges when you stop controlling.

Find Infonte at infonte.viviannedossantos.com.

But before any space, the first step is the one you've just taken: emptying. Dump, sort, choose. Ten minutes that can change your day. And if you practice regularly, they can change your relationship with

your own mind. Because the mind is not your enemy. It's a powerful tool that, without direction, works on its own. With direction (yours), it becomes your greatest ally.

This guide is a self-knowledge resource. It does not constitute therapeutic or psychological advice. If you feel your mind dominates you persistently, if you have obsessive or intrusive thoughts, or thoughts that cause you suffering, seek professional support. Help is available and seeking it is an act of intelligence and courage.

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